孩子们发明的语言

The Language the Children Invented



没有共同手语的孩子，怎样创造出一门语言？

READ 纯净阅读

CHECK 中文核对

LEARN 词汇记忆

RECALL 回想巩固

英文原文

On a rattling bus in Managua, deaf pupils kept up a brisk, voiceless hubbub across the aisle, palms fluttering, wrists flicking. Their teachers could not follow a word.

Before the late 1970s Nicaragua had no deaf community. Most deaf people led secluded lives, sharing a homemade repertoire of gestures with parents and siblings. In 1977 a special-education centre opened in Managua's San Judas district with 50 deaf pupils. By 1983 the centre and a vocational school for teenage pupils held more than 400.

The curriculum hinged on oral Spanish and lipreading, and teachers signed only the alphabet. Pupils studied lips in vain, and most failed to grasp what a Spanish word was. At recess, in the street, and on the buses, they mingled gestures with home signs. A rough jumble ripened rapidly into a coherent language entirely their own.

The teachers found it unintelligible, and in June 1986 the Ministry of Education brought in Judy Kegl, an American Sign Language linguist from MIT. A 2001 study found that pupils who arrived younger, and later intakes, used grammatical devices more often and more uniformly than their forerunners. Each fresh wave of young signers added complexity.

In a 2004 study, gesturing Spanish speakers and the earliest signers described something rolling downhill by welding how it moved and where it went into one undivided movement. Later signers dismantled it into discrete segments in linear order, a framework found nowhere in the gestures around them.

Linguists had a rare chance to watch a language grow from infancy to maturity. Its builders were not teachers or experts but deaf playmates in playgrounds, streets, and buses.

中文译文

马那瓜一辆颠簸作响的公车上，聋人学生隔着过道热烈地“聊”着天，手掌挥动，手腕轻摆，热闹却无声。老师们一个字也看不懂。

20世纪70年代末以前，尼加拉瓜尚未形成聋人社群。多数聋人生活闭塞，只与父母、兄弟姐妹共用一套自创手势。1977年，一所特殊教育中心在马那瓜圣胡达斯区开办，招收了50名聋人学生。到1983年，这所中心与一所面向青少年学生的职业学校，共有400多名学生。

课程以西班牙语口语和唇读为中心，老师只用手势比划字母。学生努力观察说话时的嘴唇，却徒劳无功；多数人连一个西班牙语单词是什么都没能弄明白。但在课间、街头和公车上，他们把一般手势与各自家中的手势混合起来。一套粗糙杂乱的表达迅速发展为一门连贯、自成体系的语言。

老师们看不懂这种语言。1986年6月，教育部请来麻省理工学院研究美国手语的语言学家朱迪·凯格尔。2001年的一项研究发现，与较早的学生相比，入学时年龄更小的学生，以及后来几批入学者，使用语法手段更频繁，也更统一。每一批新的年幼手语使用者，都为这门语言增添了复杂性。

2004年的一项研究发现，打手势的西班牙语使用者和最早一批手语使用者，在描述某个东西滚下山坡时，会把“怎样运动”和“往哪里去”合成一个不可分的动作。后来的手语使用者则把它拆成彼此独立的片段，按先后顺序表达；这种结构在他们周围人的手势中无处可寻。

语言学家难得有机会亲眼看着一门语言从初创走向成熟。创造它的不是教师或专家，而是在操场、街头和公车上一起玩耍、交流的聋人孩子。

核心词汇

先记这22项。连着下方的原文短语一起回想。

community n.
社群
no deaf community

secluded adj.
与外界隔绝的
led secluded lives

repertoire n.
掌握的一整套表达手段
a homemade repertoire of gestures

curriculum n.
课程；课程设置
The curriculum hinged on oral Spanish

hinge on 动词短语
以……为中心；取决于
hinged on oral Spanish and lipreading

in vain 介词短语
徒劳地
Pupils studied lips in vain

grasp v.
理解；领会
failed to grasp

mingle v.
混合；融合
mingled gestures with home signs

coherent adj.
连贯的；自成体系的
a coherent language

unintelligible adj.
无法理解的
The teachers found it unintelligible

linguist n.
语言学家
an American Sign Language linguist

intake n.
新招收的几批学生
later intakes

grammatical adj.
语法的
used grammatical devices

uniformly adv.
一致地；统一地
more uniformly than their forerunners

complexity n.
复杂性
added complexity

dismantle v.
拆解
dismantled it into discrete segments

discrete adj.
分立的；彼此可区分的
discrete segments in linear order

segment n.
片段
discrete segments in linear order

linear order 名词短语
线性顺序；依次排列
segments in linear order

framework n.
结构；框架
a framework found nowhere

infancy n.
初创阶段；幼年期
from infancy to maturity

maturity n.
成熟阶段
from infancy to maturity

文中词汇与搭配

补充词汇共41项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

rattle v.（分词作定语）
颠簸作响

brisk adj.
轻快热烈的

voiceless adj.
无声的

hubbub n.
喧闹；热闹的交流

aisle n.
过道

palm n.
手掌

flutter v.
挥动；轻快拍动

wrist n.
手腕

flick v.
轻快地摆动

homemade adj.
自创的；自家制作的

sibling n.
兄弟姐妹

special education n.（作定语）
特殊教育

district n.
地区；区

pupil n.
学生

vocational school 名词短语
职业学校

teenage adj.
青少年的

oral adj.
口语的

lipreading n.
唇读；看口形辨话

alphabet n.
字母表

lip n.
嘴唇；此处涉及说话口形

文中词汇与搭配 续

补充词汇共41项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

at recess 介词短语
在课间休息时

with prep.
与；同

rough adj.
粗糙的；尚未完善的

jumble n.
杂乱的混合物

ripen v.
逐渐发展成熟

rapidly adv.
迅速地

into prep.
成为；用于引出变化结果

entirely adv.
完全地

Ministry of Education 专名
教育部

bring in 动词短语
请来；引入

American Sign Language 专名
美国手语

MIT 专名
麻省理工学院

forerunner n.
较早的一批人；前辈

signer n.
手语使用者

roll v.
滚动

downhill adv.
向坡下

weld v.
熔合；把两部分合为一体

undivided adj.
未分开的；不可分的

nowhere adv.
无处

builder n.
创造者

playmate n.
玩伴

回想与回顾

先遮住下方答案，再把四个词放回原文。

01 A rough jumble ripened rapidly into a _____ language entirely their own.

02 The curriculum _____ oral Spanish and lipreading, and teachers signed only the alphabet.

03 Each fresh wave of young signers added _____.

04 Later signers dismantled it into discrete segments in _____, a framework found nowhere in the gestures around them.

文章主线

- 相聚 1977年，尼加拉瓜学校把聋童聚在一起；此前他们多只与家人用自创手势交流。
- 受阻 学校教西班牙语口语和唇读，多数学生未能掌握；课外，孩子们开始用手势相互交流。
- 自创 孩子在课间、街头和公车上交流，把自家手势混合起来，逐渐形成了一门共同语言。
- 演变 入学年龄更小的孩子和后来几批新生使语法更统一复杂；后来的孩子还把同一手势里的怎么动、往哪去拆开，按先后顺序表达。
- 意义 这门语言出自孩子的同伴交流，而非专家传授；语言学家得以观察它逐渐成熟。

参考答案　1 coherent 2 hinged on 3 complexity 4 linear order